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PARLIAMENTARY DEBATES

OFFICIAL REPORT

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THE
PARLIAMENT OF THE REPUBLIC
OF GHANA

FIRST MEETING, 2026

Friday, 27th February, 2026

*The House met at the Chamber,
Parliament House, at 9:47 a.m.*

[THE SPEAKER, RT HON ALBAN
SUMANA KINGSFORD BAGBIN, IN
THE CHAIR]

[PRAYERS]

The Speaker: Hon Members, please
resume your seats.

9:57 a.m.

May I invite the Hon Majority Leader
and the Hon Minority Leader to join me
to receive His Excellency the President
and the Vice President.

*[The Speaker, the Majority and
Minority Leaders proceeded to the
Central Lobby to receive His Excellency
the President and the Vice President and
conducted them into the Chamber.]*

—[Pause]—

10:07 a.m.

—[Pause]—

10:17 a.m.

[Pause]

10:27 a.m.

[Pause]

Hon Members, this is the Chamber of
Parliament.

Hon Members, the House is
extremely privileged to have H. E. John
Dramani Mahama, President of the
Republic and Commander-in-Chief of
the Ghana Armed Forces in this august
Chamber. His Excellency the President
is here in accordance with Article 67 of
the Constitution of the Republic to
deliver the Message on the State of the
Nation to this honourable House. On
behalf of Leadership and Hon Members,
it is my privilege and singular honour to
welcome His Excellency the President of
the Republic to this august House. *[Hear!
Hear!]*

Hon Members, before I invite His
Excellency the President to deliver the
Message on the State of the Nation,
permit me to recognise the presence in
this Chamber the following distinguished
personalities.

10:37 a.m.

Hon Members, we are blessed with
the presence of not only His Excellency,
the President of the Republic of Ghana,
but also his spouse, the First Lady, H. E.
Lordina Mahama. We also have the
presence of the Vice-President, the first
lady in Ghana to be a Vice-President, H.
E. Professor Jane Naana Opoku-
Agyeman.

[Hon Members of the Majority Side chanted]

We have His Lordship, the Chief Justice, Justice Paul Kwadwo Baffoe-Bonnie. *[Hear! Hear!]* Hon Members, he did not come alone. He came with his spouse, who, as we all know, is the Director-General of the Prison Service. I am talking about Mrs Patience Baffoe-Bonnie. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Surely, we have the presence of your Lordships, Justices of the Superior Courts with us here. We also have the Chairperson of the Council of State and the former Speaker of Parliament, Rt Hon Edward Doe Adjaho. We have the presence of the former President, His Excellency John Agyekum Kufuor.

[Hon Members of the Minority Side chanted]

Hon Members, I have a formal communication from the former President, H. E. Nana Addo Dankwa Akufo-Addo. **[Some Hon Members: Eiii!]** He expresses his gratitude to the invitation for him to be here. Unfortunately, for good reason, he is not able to attend this occasion. He however, extends his best wishes to you and to His Excellency, the President on this occasion.

Hon Members, we also have the presence of the former Speaker of Parliament, Rt Hon Ebenezer Sekyi-Hughes. I know that a lot of you are young, so you may not recollect some of these people. We also have a number of the members of the Council of State with

us here today. We have also the presence of the Chief of Staff, Hon Julius Debrah. We have with us the former Speaker of Parliament, the Rt Hon Aaron Mike Oquaye. *[Hear! Hear!]*

We have the National Chairperson of the National Democratic Congress (NDC), Hon Johnson Asiedu Nketia. We have the acting National Chairperson of the New Patriotic Party (NPP), Mr Danquah Smith Buttey. Hon Members, we have the General Secretary of the NDC, Mr Fiifi Fiavi Kwetey. And we have the General Secretary of the NPP, Mr Justin Frimpong Kodua.

For sure, we have, as usual, our brothers and sisters in the diplomatic corps. Many of them are here with us, and they are distinguishably seated at the Public Gallery. We also have the heads of the various security services. We have our revered traditional leaders, religious leaders, and the former Clerks to Parliament.

10:47 a.m.

Hon Members, on your behalf, I warmly welcome all of them to the House. Now, I have the greatest pleasure in inviting His Excellency the President to deliver his message. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Your Excellency, you may do so now.

[Hon Members from the Majority chanted]

[Hon Members from the Minority chanted]

MESSAGE ON THE STATE OF THE NATION, 2026

His Excellency the President (Mr John Dramani Mahama): Thank you, Mr Speaker.

Hon Members of this august House, Your Excellency the Vice President, Prof Jane Naana Opoku-Agyemang, Your Lordship the Chief Justice, the good people of Ghana, friends of the media, and let me proceed on the protocol so well established by the Speaker and say, distinguished guests, ladies and gentlemen. It is both a profound honour and a constitutional duty to appear before this august House to deliver a Message on the State of the Nation as required by Article 67 of the 1992 Constitution.

I do this with the perspective and through decades of public service, including my time in this very Chamber as a Member of Parliament representing Bole Bamboi and my previous term of office as President of the Republic from 2012 to 2017. My journey in public service, like that of our nation, has not followed a straight path. It has been marked by periods of steady progress, setbacks, and determined recovery.

Mr Speaker, that pattern of resilience mirrors the national experience of our nation. Today, I stand before you to speak to another such defining moment, a moment in which our nation is on the rebound of national renewal and of restored hope. This moment is being shaped by hard choices, institutional resolve, and a renewed commitment to stability and national purpose. Mr

Speaker, in just a few days, on 6th March, 2026, our dear nation, Ghana, will celebrate 69 years of independence on the theme “Building Prosperity, Restoring Hope”. This theme is not merely ceremonial. It is the blueprint that guides our administration’s vision and actions. It reflects where we have been. It acknowledges the difficulties we have endured and confidently declares the direction in which we are heading.

At the heart of this vision are two complementary and mutually reinforcing agendas: One, the Resetting Ghana Agenda, and two, the Accra Reset. The Resetting Ghana Agenda is our national commitment to restore economic stability, rebuild public trust in our democracy, strengthen our institutions, and deliver tangible improvements in the lives of ordinary Ghanaians. It is about turning the page on years of mismanagement and confronting our challenges with honesty and charting a new course anchored in fiscal discipline, transparency, and sustainable development.

The Accra Reset, on the other hand, is our continental commitment. This agenda recognises that Ghana’s prosperity cannot be separated from Africa’s progress. It calls for a fundamental shift in how African nations relate to one another and to the world; from dependence to self-reliance, from fragmentation to integration, and from reactive postures to strategic leadership. Mr Speaker, these two agendas are deeply interlinked because we cannot build lasting prosperity at home without contributing to stability and growth

across our continent. Equally, we cannot lead effectively on the continental stage if our own house is not in order. Together, these frameworks demonstrate our determination to restore hope, not merely as a promise, but as a lived reality of Ghanaians and Africans alike.

As we build on the foundation laid in 2025, the first year of my return to the Presidency, we do so with clarity of purpose, unity of action, and confidence in our ability to deliver a future worthy of our people's sacrifice and their aspirations. Mr Speaker, this moment of national renewal unfolds against the backdrop of a world in profound flux. The global order we once knew is being rapidly reshaped, and the so-called rule-based international system endures only as long as it protects the advantages of those who designed it.

Once emerging nations like ours begin to operate within those same rules to rebalance power, the very architects of that order prove willing to relax their commitments. Ghana, like many nations, has learned this hard truth. We cannot respond to this new reality with fragmentation, hesitation, or continued dependence. History has long taught us that resilience and prosperity will not be handed to us. They must be built deliberately through cooperation, self-belief, and strategic alignment. This era ahead demands that Africa must move from a posture of dependence to one of collective self-reliance.

Mr Speaker, it is in this spirit that Ghana has sought to play a convenient and catalytic role on the continent. In the

middle of last year, our capital, Accra, hosted African Heads of State, Policy-makers, and Development Partners for a landmark Health Sovereignty Summit. Together, we charted a new roadmap for health care financing and collaboration among African nations. And that message was clear; Africa must take ownership of its health security, pool its resources, deepen collaboration, and design financing solutions that reflect our realities rather than external prescriptions. Strong economies require healthy populations, and health sovereignty is inseparable from economic sovereignty. The same logic applies to trade, industry, and economic growth.

Africa's future lies in dismantling our artificial borders, removing bottlenecks that stifle commerce, and fully activating a common market that allows our goods, services, capital, and ideas to move freely across the continent. No single African country, no matter how well endowed, can thrive alone in this new global environment. Rather, when we work together, our combined markets, our youthful populations, our natural resources, and our creativity will constitute one of the greatest economic opportunities of this century. Africa must summon the courage to shape its own destiny, building genuine sovereignty across Africa. The Global South requires a deliberate and disciplined plan, one that begins with unlocking the immense human and creative potential of our young people, strengthening regional value chains to add value to what we produce, mobilising domestic capital to finance our own development, and speaking with a single, coordinated, and confident voice in global affairs.

Mr Speaker, this is how Africa can move from promise to power, from participation to leadership, and from dependence to self-reliance. The path forward is clear. Africa must rise with confidence, unity, and purpose. Ghana stands ready not only to rebuild at home but also to work hand-in-hand with our African brothers and sisters to shape a future that is defined by shared strength, dignity, and prosperity.

10:57 a.m.

Mr Speaker, we have resolved here in Ghana to operate with our eyes open, to protect our sovereignty and to design policies that place our people first. We will continue to engage with the world, but on terms that reflect our interests. We will uphold global norms, but we will not outsource our judgement. And we will build resilience at home so that shifts in external power do not translate into hardship for our citizens.

Mr Speaker, when I last came before this House, I spoke candidly about the depth of the challenges we had inherited across all facets of our nation. Nowhere was this national malaise more evident than in the economic sector. We inherited an economy in severe crisis—burdened by unsustainable debts, high inflation, a rapidly depreciating currency, and an escalating cost-of-living crisis that had left our citizens reeling from unimaginable hardship caused by years of general imprudence and reckless management of the economy. I was clear from the outset that recovery would not come easily. But I was also clear that I would stop at

nothing to turn this situation around and bring relief to Ghanaians. *[Hear! Hear!]* I promised then that just as we have confronted and overcome crisis in the past, I would reset our economy and return us to a path of growth, progress, and development. *[Hear! Hear!]* I told this august House then, when I appeared before you last year, that we would have to take tough, prudent, and necessary decisions to restore stability and credibility.

Today, Mr Speaker, I can say with confidence, Ghana is back. *[Hear! Hear!]* Ghana is working again; and Ghana is open for business. The fundamentals are improving, and the path to sustained acceleration is very clear to everyone. From the outset, we resolved to choose discipline over waste, reform over excuses, and stability over speculation. As a responsible Government, our first order of business was to halt the economic haemorrhaging and restore order to our public finances. We tightened expenditure and commitment controls. We improved payables reporting and conducted a comprehensive audit of 2024 commitments to restore credibility and discipline. These measures have begun to deliver some of the most remarkable economic outcomes in decades.

Mr Speaker, as we approach the celebration of our 69th Independence Anniversary, we do so not only with pride in our past, but also with renewed hope for our future. We are building prosperity through sound policy, responsible governance, and inclusive growth. We are restoring hope by

delivering on our promises and proving that good leadership makes a measurable difference in the lives of our people. The Resetting Ghana Agenda is working. The Accra Reset is gaining momentum and together they are laying the foundation for a stronger, more resilient, and more prosperous Ghana.

Mr Speaker, our nation is on the runway. It is in take-off mode, and you are all advised to fasten your seatbelts.

Mr Speaker, the journey continues, the direction is set, and the hope is real. Our theme today of building prosperity, restoring hope, is not merely aspirational. It reflects the tangible transformation we have delivered for the Ghanaian people. Our economy has grown significantly. In 2025, Ghana's GDP is expected to reach US\$113 billion, an increase from US\$83 billion at the end of 2024. This has placed Ghana among the top 10 largest economies in Africa. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, average GDP growth for the first three quarters of 2025 is reported at 6.1 per cent. But growth means nothing without discipline. Our primary surplus reached 2.6 per cent of GDP, far exceeding our target of 1.5 per cent. We closed our fiscal deficit at 3.1 per cent, well below the projected 3.8 per cent. This is not just prudent governance; it is promise-keeping and it has benefited households and businesses because we have borrowed less and spent more responsibly. Interest rates have fallen. Confidence has returned. Private businesses are breathing again.

Mr Speaker, the 19th of December, 2022 will go down as one of the darkest days in Ghana's economic history. On that day, Ghana declared its inability to honour its debt obligations. We declared a debt default and placed a moratorium on both domestic and foreign debt repayments. Following this, we entered a protracted and complex debt restructuring process. Ghana's debt became a shackle on our economic progress, dragging our nation down into hardship and despair. Looking at Ghana's restructured debt profile, it is clear that those who negotiated on our behalf were only intent on kicking the can down the road. With the largest debt repayments scheduled interestingly between 2025 and 2028.

Mr Speaker, we confronted this crisis with action, not rhetoric. We established sinking funds, we restructured obligations, and we pursued bilateral agreements. Mr Speaker, the result? Public debt fell by GH¢82.1 billion and took our debt to GDP from 61.8 per cent to 45.3 per cent. This is one of the sharpest reductions of debt in the history of Ghana.

Mr Speaker, just this year, after the New Year celebration on 2nd January, when people were still recovering from hung overs, we settled a US\$709 million Eurobond ahead of schedule, completing the US\$1.4 billion in debt service that was meant for 2025, and the world noticed. Fitch, Moody's, and Standards and Poor, all upgraded Ghana's credit ratings. The first triple upgrade in many years.

Mr Speaker, Ghana's credibility is restored. Ghana is rising. The heaviest burden we inherited was a very high

inflation rate, which was silently eroding the purchasing power of every household. It peaked at 54.1 per cent at the end of 2022, and it declined to 23.5 per cent by the end of 2024. We treated this with urgency.

11:07 a.m.

Through fiscal consolidation, currency stabilisation, and disciplined monetary policy, inflation fell from 23.5 per cent at the end of 2024 to 3.8 per cent over 13 consecutive months by January 2026.

Mr Speaker, interestingly, food inflation, which had been the main driver of the upward pressure on inflation, fell by 26.6 percentage points. Inflation for locally produced goods fell by 22.6 percentage points. These are not just statistics. These translate into the reality of a parent being able to put food on the table for their children. *[Hear! Hear!]* It translates into the reality of businesses thriving and creating opportunities for Ghana's young people.

Mr Speaker, petrol prices dropped from GH¢15.20 to GH¢10.70 cedis per litre and only recently, it dipped below the GH¢10 mark to GH¢9.97 per litre. Diesel fell from GH¢15.40 per litre to GH¢11.30 per litre. This brought relief to our nation's 3.7 million car owners and the tens of millions of Ghanaians who depend on transport daily.

Mr Speaker, to the interesting part, exchange rate volatility has long been at the heart of hardship in Ghanaian households. We made currency stability a priority, and we have delivered. *[Hear!*

Hear!] We did not arrest the dollar; we strengthened the cedi to put up a good fight against the other currencies. *[Hear! Hear!]* I am pleased to report to this House that the cedi appreciated by 40.7 per cent against the US dollar, by 30.9 per cent against the British pound, and by 24 per cent against the euro.

Mr Speaker, Ghana's economic turnaround is broad-based and comprehensive. All sectors of the Ghanaian economy have witnessed remarkable improvements in our first year in office. Most importantly, Ghana's economy has surpassed the US\$100 billion mark for the first time. And as I said, it is projected to place Ghana among the top 10 largest economies in Africa. Mr Speaker, our reserves currently stand at US\$13.8 billion, from US\$8.9 billion at the end of 2024. This covers 5.7 months of import. A key driver of this development has been the establishment of the Ghana Gold Board. By formalising gold exports, we have reduced smuggling, increased recorded exports in the artisanal and small-scale mining sector from 63.6 tonnes to 103 tonnes, and channelled that foreign exchange into our economy.

Mr Speaker, when the cedi stabilises, imported inflation falls, businesses can plan better, and household incomes improve. As global uncertainty grows, it is necessary for us to reduce our country's exposure to external shocks, break the cycle of economic downturns, and safeguard our macroeconomic stability. Just last Wednesday, 25th February, 2026, the Minister for Finance

presented the Ghana Accelerated National Reserve Accumulation Policy (GANRAP) to this House.

Mr Speaker, this policy seeks to strengthen our country's external resilience by increasing our international reserves to 15 months of import cover by the end of 2028. Supporting long-term structural transformation while safeguarding macroeconomic stability. It is forecast that gold prices will remain high over the next three years. And so this presents us with a unique opportunity to build an economic war chest to withstand any global economic shocks, secure our macroeconomic stability, improve the standards of living of our citizens, and build lasting prosperity for future generations. This is what the GANRAP policy seeks to achieve.

Mr Speaker, we abolished nuisance taxes that were levied on Ghanaians between 2017 and 2024. These included the E-Levy, the Betting Tax, the Emission Tax, the COVID-19 Levy, and so forth. We have reformed Value Added Tax (VAT) comprehensively. One, by abolishing the 1 per cent COVID-19 levy, decoupling the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund) and the National Health Insurance Levy (NHIL) from VAT, reducing the effective VAT rate from 21.9 to 20 per cent, raising the VAT threshold to GHC750,000 to exclude petty businesses, and extending zero rating on textiles up to 2028.

Mr Speaker, these fiscal reforms have effectively put GHC6 billion back into the pockets of Ghanaians. Interest

rates have fallen from above 30 per cent to currently between 18 and 20 per cent, freeing up credit for businesses and households. According to the Ghana Statistical Service, over one million Ghanaians have found employment between quarter one and quarter three of 2025. [**Some Hon Members:** Eii!] And 950,000 Ghanaians have escaped multidimensional poverty over the same period.

Mr Speaker, I am pleased to report that our external position has strengthened significantly. By December 2025, our current account recorded a surplus of US\$9.1 billion, representing 8.1 per cent of our GDP. This is a remarkable increase from US\$1.5 billion or 1.8 per cent of GDP in 2024. These achievements have been driven by robust gold, cocoa and non-traditional exports, and increased remittance inflows. This improvement demonstrates that our economy is gaining strength and resilience again on the global stage. We have moved decisively from planning to action on our flagship 24-Hour Economy and Accelerated Export Development Programme. This was officially launched in 2025. This transformative initiative is designed, one, to unlock round-the-clock economic activity. Two, deepen our value chains across key sectors. Three, boost productivity and support export growth. And four, create quality jobs in agriculture, manufacturing, logistics and services.

Mr Speaker, I want to thank this august House. On 6th February 2026, this House passed the 24-Hour Economy Authority Bill. [*Hear! Hear!*] This has

established the regulatory framework and the legal mandate that were necessary for full implementation. Last week, at the Cabinet meeting held, I had the honour of signing this historic legislation into law. All is now set for take-off. This is the boldest economic transformation initiative in Ghana's recent history.

Mr Speaker, in this year's budget, GH¢110 million has been allocated to begin the setting up and implementation of the 24-Hour Economy Authority. These resources will enable businesses to operate beyond traditional business hours. They will attract investment through strategic partnerships with the Development Bank of Ghana and the Ghana Infrastructure Investment Fund (GIIF) and they will strengthen the foundations for sustained growth and job creation, especially for our young people. This is about building prosperity and restoring our people's hope through concrete action.

Mr Speaker, a nation that does not learn from past mistakes cannot get out of the cycle of problems that impose hardships on its citizens. We have just begun to emerge from the most devastating economic crisis in our nation's recent history. This crisis was triggered by general financial indiscipline, huge deficits and massive debts that were occasioned by persistent and budgeted expenditure to meet the ends of convenient politicking. In the last week, we have had to take the painful but necessary decision to revise the producer price of cocoa to achieve competitive pricing and resolve the acute liquidity challenges in the sector.

11:17 a.m.

Mr Speaker, failure to do this, as others did, and left a debt of GH¢32 billion for this Government to pay, failure to do this would have meant borrowing billions in borrowed funds.

Mr Speaker, this unplanned expenditure would have taken us right back to the very devastating economic problems we have only recently begun to escape. So, while fully understanding the concerns and protests of our farmers, I can firmly assure them that the reforms announced by the Government will see a total transformation of the cocoa sector, and it will guarantee them a fair and transparent price that enables them to meet the cost of producing the commodity and make decent margins.

Mr Speaker, the difference between facing economic hardships and avoiding the same is the exercise of sound economic judgement, and I am determined to take decisions that ensure our collective wellbeing and avoid the suffering of all our citizens. These are difficult decisions to take, but Mr Speaker, I had to take them.

Mr Speaker, we are bringing legislation to this House to tighten our procurement processes by banning sole-sourced contracts, except in exceptional circumstances. We will also bring legislation to this House to make it mandatory to seek Parliament's prior approval before any government asset or property is leased out or sold. This includes lands and state enterprises.

Mr Speaker, last Tuesday, I caused the Minister for Finance to lay before this august House the Value for Money Office Bill. This is a landmark measure, a fulfilment of yet another campaign promise to the good people of Ghana, and this is designed to decisively end waste, inflated contracts, abandoned projects and chronic cost overruns that have, for far too long, drained the public purse. All these measures are intended to improve public trust and accountability.

Mr Speaker, in January 2025, we inherited an energy sector on the brink of collapse that had been precipitated by a severe financial crisis. The sector was burdened with the staggering debt of GH¢80 billion, threatening the operational viability of key power producers. The US\$500 million World Bank Partial Risk Guarantee (PRG), a critical risk-mitigation instrument that was established in 2015 during my first term to safeguard the nearly US\$8 billion of private sector investment that was put into the Offshore Cape Three Points (OCTP) field, had been fully drawn down and exhausted due to prolonged non-payment for gas consumed.

Mr Speaker, at the distribution level, the Electricity Company of Ghana (ECG) was plagued by high commercial and technical losses, collecting only 62 per cent of the energy it purchased from generators and declaring less than 50 per cent of its collection into the Cash Waterfall Mechanism (CWM).

Mr Speaker, the result was severe liquidity shortfalls and power supply challenges throughout 2024.

In the petroleum sector, years of policy inconsistency, regulatory inefficiencies, a lack of transparency, prolonged licencing processes, and unresolved legal disputes over field unitisation had eroded investor confidence. Consequently, crude oil production declined by approximately 32 per cent between 2019 and 2024. It fell from 71.4 million barrels per day to 48.2 million barrels.

Mr Speaker, I am pleased to announce that as of 31st December, 2025, the Government has fully repaid and restored the entire US\$500 million World Bank PRG, including interest. This has reinstated the facility in full and reaffirmed Ghana's standing as a credible and reliable partner on the global stage.

Mr Speaker, I can also announce that we are paying for every gas we are consuming today. In addition, between January and December 2025, through carefully coordinated policy actions, the Government settled all outstanding gas invoices owed to Eni Ghana and Vitol Upstream Ghana Ltd (Vitol), amounting to approximately US\$500 million. So, Ghana is now fully up to date with its gas consumption obligations to the Sankofa Partners.

[Hon Members on the Majority Side chanted]

I am pleased to announce that the 2026 Budget has made adequate provision to ensure timely payments for all liquefied natural gas (LNG) that we consume going forward.

Mr Speaker, to ensure equity and fairness, the Government has also held constructive engagements with Tullow Oil Public Limited Company (Tullow Oil plc) and the Jubilee Field Partners, and we have reached a comprehensive roadmap to guarantee full payment for all gas that is consumed. This approach supports reliable nationwide electricity generation and accelerates industrial growth. Engagement with upstream partners has resulted in increased gas production, guided by a clear national vision to rapidly scale up domestic gas supply and reduce reliance on expensive liquid fuels.

Mr Speaker, beyond clearing inherited areas, a robust framework has also been established to strengthen and monitor the implementation of the Cash Waterfall Mechanism. Another major milestone was the operationalisation of the ECG Single Holding Account, which is overseen jointly by the Ministry of Energy and Green Transition and the Public Utilities Regulatory Commission (PURC). This intervention has significantly reduced revenue leakages, and it has enhanced ECG's capacity to meet its payment obligations.

To address the high cost of power, the Government has successfully renegotiated existing power purchase agreements. Engagements with the nine independent power producers have resulted in a US\$250 million immediate savings and US\$1.1 billion of legacy debt restructured for payments between the period 2026 and 2028. These revised agreements will be submitted to Cabinet,

and I am pleased to inform you, Mr Speaker, that it would be brought here to Parliament for ratification.

Mr Speaker, under the Rural Electrification Programme, 200 out of the 400 targeted communities have been connected to the national grid, with a further 100 at various stages of completion. The national electricity access for Ghana today stands at 89.05 per cent. We are committed to ensuring that every Ghanaian has access to reliable, affordable electricity. It is worrying that the ECG continues to experience high power losses, with reports indicating that around 25 per cent of generated power is lost. To address this phenomenon and anchor the gains we have made, adopting private sector participation, particularly in billing and collections, is the most effective way to significantly reduce these losses. Cabinet has approved the multiple lease method for concessions in the distribution utilities, and work is ongoing to implement this critical reform.

Mr Speaker, the Bui Power Authority has completed an additional 50 megawatts of solar power. In the distributed solar sector, 30 megawatts were achieved through rooftop installations, bringing our total installed capacity to 285 megawatts of solar, and this represents 5 per cent of renewable energy in our entire generation mix. A few months ago, I broke ground for a 200 megawatt solar power project at the Dawa Industrial Zone, with the first 100 megawatts scheduled for completion in December 2026. The Ministry of Energy and Green Transition is constructing 35

mini-grids to serve 47 islands and lakeside communities in the Oti, Savannah and Bono East Regions.

The Ministry will also supply 12,000 new smart net metres from the end of the first quarter of this year, 2026, and under the off-grid solar home system for public institutions, delivery of materials for the first phase of 350 systems has commenced. It means that public institutions are going to be fitted with solar to reduce their power consumption.

11:27 a.m.

Mr Speaker, as part of the last-mile electrification effort to achieve 99.98 per cent universal access by 2030, the Ministry has mainstreamed mini-grids into the National Electrification Scheme (NES). Consequently, a feasibility study for the Afram Plains North District was completed for 100 communities to receive solar power, bringing the total number of islands and lakeside communities in the Afram Plains North and South to 150 that are ready for mini-grid solar electrification.

I am pleased to announce that the African Development Bank has committed to providing US\$100 million to fund the construction of renewable energy-based mini-grids for these communities.

Mr Speaker, we have signed a Memorandum of Understanding with the Jubilee and Tweneboa, Enyenra, Ntomme (TEN) field partners to commit another US\$2 billion to additional investment in

the Jubilee field. This will include drilling up to 20 new wells. The first well is being drilled in more than nine years. Mr Speaker, there is a second Memorandum of Intent with the Offshore Cape Three Points (OCTP) partners, that is ENI Ghana Exploration and Production and Vitol Ghana Services Limited, to commit US\$1.5 billion of additional investment in the OCTP field in the Cape Three Points Block 4 Contract Area, among others. This agreement will significantly increase Ghana's oil and gas production, thereby enhancing energy security, domestic demand and infrastructure development.

Mr Speaker, we are on course to revitalise the Ghana Cylinder Manufacturing Company through a strategic partnership with the National Petroleum Authority, Ghana Gas and the Ghana Commercial Bank. This will boost production, ensure a steady supply of safe LPG cylinders and strengthen local manufacturing.

Mr Speaker, I am also pleased to announce to you that Tema Oil Refinery is back. [*Hear! Hear!*]

[Members of the Majority chanted]

H.E Mahama: The new management of the refinery has successfully completed extensive turnaround maintenance. I am pleased to inform this august House that for the first time since 2018, the refinery has commenced processing of crude oil into petroleum products again.

So, Mr Speaker, let me assure our countrymen and women that the energy sector reforms continue unabated. I remain fully committed to turning around the sector, strengthening its foundations and ensuring reliable, affordable, and sustainable energy security for our nation.

Mr Speaker, agriculture remains central to our national renewal. Since January 2025, this administration has embarked on a decisive reset of Ghana's agricultural sector under our Agriculture for Economic Transformation agenda, with the Feed Ghana Programme serving as the flagship vehicle for implementation. Our objective is clear: to restore food sovereignty, stabilise food prices, reduce import dependence, increase decent jobs especially for the youth and reposition agriculture as a strategic growth sector under our 24-Hour Economy policy. Mr Speaker, as of January 2025, food inflation stood at 28.3 per cent, following an unprecedented peak of 61 per cent in January 2023. This situation placed severe pressure on households and undermined national stability. Today, food inflation has declined significantly to 4.9 per cent and this has provided relief to Ghanaian families and businesses.

Mr Speaker, this year we have committed GH¢300 million to the National Food Buffer Stock Company to mop up excess produce to stabilise prices and build a strategic national food buffer against emergencies, marking the first time Ghana has deliberately built a food reserve for national resilience. Over 413

institutions, from basic schools through to tertiary institutions, have been registered and are actively participating in the Feed Ghana Programme. Institutional farming is currently being undertaken by the Ghana Armed Forces, the Ghana Prisons Service, the National Service Authority, basic and second cycle schools, public universities, and faith-based organisations, including churches and mosques.

A key pillar of the Feed Ghana Programme is the Home Gardening Initiative. Across the country, families are being encouraged to grow vegetables at home and in their communities to reduce food expenditure, improve household nutrition and enhance food availability. The Feed Ghana programme is also firmly anchored on Irrigation for Wealth Creation. Government is deliberately shifting our agriculture from rain-fed dependence to irrigation-based farming to support year-round production and strengthen our climate resilience.

Over the past months, processes have begun for the following interventions: the construction of 10 new small-dams, the rehabilitation of eight existing irrigation dams and the construction of 250 solar-powered boreholes for farming communities and schools across the northern belt and Brong Ahafo regions. In addition, major irrigation schemes including the Veia, Weta, Tanoso, Kpong, Ashaiman and Aveyime are undergoing rehabilitation, while new inland valleys covering over 1,300 hectares are being developed to expand rice production.

Under the Global Agriculture and Food Security Programme (GAFSP), we have launched a US\$20 million Agro-Input Distribution Project to strengthen food and nutrition security across the Northern Savannah Ecological Zone. This project is being implemented in 12 districts across six regions with a target of 50,000 farming households, including 30,000 women and youth. It will support the production of key staples such as maize, rice, soybean, cowpea and groundnuts while promoting year-round vegetable cultivation through solar-powered micro-irrigation schemes for farmers' groups and selected schools. The project is also supporting backyard and commercial poultry production, as well as the distribution of fertiliser and certified seeds to participating districts. This will help strengthen the poultry value chain.

We are working to fulfil the promise of establishing Farmer Services Centres across the country to modernise agriculture. Procurement processes are underway for a total of 660 tractors, 400 combine harvesters and more than 4,000 agricultural machines and implements. The first 11 farmers service centres will begin construction this year and will provide affordable access to land preparation, harvesting, storage, input supply, extension services and equipment leasing, especially for smallholder farmers. Mr Speaker, in the next two weeks, I am going to inaugurate the first farmers' service centre in the Afram Plains. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, agriculture extension remains the backbone of productivity. To address the current gap between farmers

and extension officers, 540 motorbikes have been procured to improve extension coverage. About 150 of those bikes have already been distributed and we are employing 400 Feed Ghana District Coordinators nationwide, while 10,000 young Ghanaians are being enrolled under a four-year National Service Agripreneur Programme with annual absorption into permanent employment. So far, 3,000 youth have been posted by the National Service Authority under the Agripreneur Programme. This intervention is strengthening frontline service delivery and creating employment opportunities for young people.

We are also placing farmer cooperatives at the centre of our agricultural transformation plan. As of October 2025, 70,000 Community Commodity-Focused Farmers Cooperatives had been established nationwide. They are serving as platforms to access inputs, mechanisation services, climate advisories, aggregation and fair market negotiation. Government is actively linking farmers to agro-industrial investments to stabilise prices, create jobs and accelerate Ghana's journey towards food security. A major highlight of this effort is the €154 million Ghana-Italy irrigated commercial farming project to establish a 10,000-hectare irrigation model farm to produce rice, maize, soya and tomatoes. All produce from this project will be sold locally. This intervention is strategic and designed to fast-track progress towards food security, ensure a reliable supply of raw materials for agro-processing and reduce Ghana's dependence on food imports.

Mr Speaker, other key initiatives under the value addition and agro-industrial drive include rice processing facilities in the Upper East and Upper West Regions, poultry feed production facilities in Ashanti, cashew and onion processing facilities in Bono East.

11:37 a.m.

In addition, a 40-tonne per day soya processing plant is being established in northern Ghana to support soybean farmers and reduce their feed costs. The shea industry is also being revived through secured export contracts and measures to protect raw material supplies.

Mr Speaker, to reduce Ghana's 300 to 400 million Annual Poultry Import Bill, Ghana has launched a comprehensive Poultry Farm-to-Table Project. These comprise 50 anchor or commercial farmers producing four million birds, 500 SMEs producing three million birds, and a small-scale (Nkoko Nketenkete) backyard poultry programme that is targeting three million birds nationwide, with emphasis on women and young children. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, the Nkoko Nketenkete Programme is underway as I speak, and the target is to reach 60,000 households. Even before I launched the Nkoko Nketenkete Programme, 720,000 birds had been distributed during the pilot phase to 13,000 farmers in 12 districts. I recently opened a poultry processing factory in Bechem to support expected production growth in the poultry sector.

Mr Speaker, education is important and it remains pivotal to our national transformation agenda. In this regard, the year 2025 was both eventful and momentous for Ghana's education sector. I am pleased to report that all the flagship initiatives and commitments that were contained in our Reset Agenda Manifesto have been faithfully honoured during the year under review. The No-Fee Stress Initiative was successfully launched in Koforidua and, as I speak, has benefited over 152,698 young first-year students in public tertiary universities. The number of beneficiaries this year is projected to reach 220,000 first-year students.

In collaboration with the Student Loan Trust Fund, I have good news for law students. Law students in Ghana will also be now able to access the student loan scheme to pursue their legal education.

Mr Speaker, the Free Tertiary Education Policy for Persons with Disabilities has also been launched, and is now fully benefiting all eligible persons with disabilities enrolled in our tertiary institutions nationwide. The 2025 academic year saw a stable uninterrupted supply of quality food to all our schools under the Free Senior High School Programme.

To further deepen coordination, accountability and effectiveness in the education sector, this honourable House passed several important pieces of legislation. These include the Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and

Technology Bill, 2025, the Ghana Scholarships Authority Bill, 2025, the Change of University Names Bill, 2025, the University for Development Studies Bill 2025, and the Ghana Education Trust Fund (GETFund) Bill, 2025.

To enhance private sector participation in the tertiary education sector, new legislation will be introduced in this House to ease regulatory bottlenecks and remove the requirement to charter, making it optional.

Mr Speaker, basic education remains the critical entry point into our education system. It is at this level that children acquire foundational literacy, numeracy, critical thinking and problem-solving skills, upon which all future learning depends. Government understands the importance of the basic sector and is therefore undertaking a major policy shift to rebalance our education investments in favour of basic education. As part of this shift, the Standards-Based Curriculum for kindergarten to primary six is currently under review to incorporate robotics, coding and the responsible integration of generative artificial intelligence.

Additionally, as part of the ongoing curriculum review, artificial intelligence education will be introduced at an age appropriate and developmentally sensitive, with a strong emphasis on ethical use, digital responsibility, critical thinking and human values.

Mr Speaker, in response to the persisting challenge of schools under trees, this Government has programmed a bold and decisive intervention for the 2026 financial year. This includes the construction of 200 kindergarten blocks, 200 new primary school blocks, 200 new Junior High Schools nationwide. Adequate allocation has been done in the 2026 Budget.

And I am further pleased to inform this House that the Government has fully cleared all outstanding Capitation Grant arrears owed to the public basic schools, as well as clearing all outstanding arrears of Basic Education Certificate Examination (BECE) registration subsidies due to the West African Examinations Council (WAEC). For previous years, the legacy debts to the WAEC have all been cleared.

Mr Speaker, education for learners with special needs is not only a moral right but also a sound, pragmatic investment, and it promotes equity and strengthens social cohesion. In recognition of this, the amended GETFund Act has established a dedicated, sustainable funding framework to implement free education for learners with special needs, beginning in the 2026 academic year. Government has also increased the daily feeding grants for students in public special schools from GH¢8 per day to GH¢15 per day. This significant increment reflects our resolve to address the unique nutritional and health needs of learners with disability.

In addition, Mr Speaker, we will construct a modern, state-of-the-art special needs school in Ho in the Volta region, and will rehabilitate and upgrade the existing special needs schools in Akropong-Akuapem. In fulfilment of our pledge also to provide free sanitary pads to schoolgirls as part of efforts to improve menstrual hygiene and reduce absenteeism among female learners, a total of 12.2 million packs of sanitary pads were distributed to girls in public schools across the country in 2025.

We allocated in this year's budget GH¢292.4 million to sustain the Free Sanitary Pad Initiative. This commitment aims to remove gender-specific barriers to education and ensure that no girl's education is interrupted due to challenges related to her menstrual hygiene.

Mr Speaker, as part of efforts to decongest senior high schools and increase access and ensure parity in educational opportunities, Government is going to convert and upgrade 30 Category C secondary schools to Category B, and convert and upgrade 10 Category B schools to Category A. In addition, facilities in Category A schools are going to be upgraded and expanded to be able to take in more children. Technical and vocational education and training remain a critical pillar of our strategy to address youth unemployment and accelerate skills development.

Government will construct six brand-new regional Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET) centres

of excellence across the country to equip our young people with practical, industry-relevant skills aligned with the demands of the evolving job market. We are also undertaking a review of the National Curriculum to align with the Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development (OECD) Future of Education and Skills Framework. This will make TVET education more adaptive and resilient.

Mr Speaker, to expand access to higher education and support balanced regional growth and meet the rising demand for quality tertiary education, we have international partnerships to establish two new public universities, one in Kintampo in the Bono East Region and another in Jasikan in the Oti Region. I am happy to announce that a grant has been sourced from China to establish a new public university in Damongo in the Savannah Region. *[Hear! Hear!]* Mr Speaker, technical universities play a critical role in closing the skills gap and reducing youth unemployment by delivering high-quality, industry-aligned and practice-orientated training within a broader policy framework that stimulates labour demand.

11:47 a.m.

In this regard, the Government will establish three new technical universities to strengthen skills development, enhance innovation, and support national industrialisation efforts.

Mr Speaker, the teachers' housing initiative is a joint effort involving District Assemblies Common Fund,

GETFund, Ghana National Association of Teachers (GNAT), and Ghana Education Service Occupational Pension Scheme (GESOPS). The aim is to build 50,000 housing units for teachers. This initiative is called the Teacher Dabrɛ, Bɛɛbi a Teacher Bɛda Project. This partnership demonstrates our collective dedication to enhancing teachers' living conditions and boosting the retention of teachers, especially in rural and remote areas, and ensuring that teachers can live, work, and retire with dignity and security. Mr Speaker, by prioritising equitable access and expanding infrastructure, we are investing in human capital and laying the foundation for a Ghana where every child can learn, grow, and succeed.

Mr Speaker, by January 2025, our health system was under severe strain. Ageing and deteriorating equipment, stalled hospital projects, amounting to GH¢15 billion in liabilities, and growing workforce pressures had weakened service delivery. Over the past year, donor support to our health sector declined sharply from 19 per cent of our total health budget to just 2.2 per cent today, creating an annual financing gap of more than GH¢2.4 billion. The withdrawal of support from programmes previously financed by partners such as the United States Agency for International Development (USAID) exposed the vulnerability in essential supplies and services, particularly in remote and underserved communities. Faced with these realities, my Government chose to act decisively.

In 2026, direct Government funding for health will account for about 72 per cent of our total health spending. This is

up from 56.8 per cent in 2023. Core health allocations have risen to GH¢23.3 billion, and with national health insurance resources included. Total health financing now stands at GH¢34.7 billion. [*Hear! Hear!*]— This reflects our clear commitment to domestic financing and health sovereignty. At the same time, we have faced the growing burden of non-communicable diseases. Today, non-communicable diseases account for over 40 per cent of all deaths in Ghana, and remain a major cause of household poverty.

To address this, the Government established the Ghana Medical Trust Fund, otherwise called MahamaCares. This is the first nationwide financing mechanism dedicated to chronic and non-communicable diseases. The National Health Insurance Levy (NHIL) has been uncapped. Claims payments are now timely, with facilities no longer waiting more than six months, as happened in the past, for payment to be made. We are also finalising measures to increase provider tariffs by over 100 per cent to reflect the realistic cost of health treatment. As a result of the increased trust, National Health Insurance Scheme (NHIS) enrolment has risen from 57 per cent at the start of 2025 to 66 per cent today.

Mr Speaker, Ghana's health workforce density has risen from 16.6 per 10,000 people in 2025 to nearly 42 per 10,000 today, while public sector health employment has doubled to approximately 200,000 workers. Yet, significant challenges remain. At the beginning of 2025, when we took over,

103,000 trained health workers were still awaiting placement, employment, or enrolment onto the payroll. Over the past year, 13,500 nurses and midwives, along with hundreds of doctors and pharmacists, have been absorbed into the public payroll. Nursing trainee allowances have been regularised and restored. Application fees have been reduced, and the no-fee stress initiative introduced to ease access to training has been extended. Service conditions are being implemented to boost morale and retention. Looking ahead, Government will expand recruitment and take necessary action to add more health workers onto the payroll.

We will also correct the maldistribution of health workers through targeted incentives for health workers who agree to serve in underserved areas. Let me use this opportunity to appeal to our gallant health workers to accept postings to our underserved areas, seeing as it is a national call to duty, while we work to ensure they have an enabling environment to do their work. We will also scale up specialist and advanced nursing training to match the country's changing disease profile. New post-basic nursing programmes in Cardiology, Nephrology, Endocrinology, and Oncology will be introduced. With the two existing ones, emergency and critical care nurses will be scaled up. At least 30 nursing training institutions will transition to competency-based degree curricula, supported by new scholarship opportunities for PhD level training for nurses and allied health professionals.

On health infrastructure, my Government remains firm in its commitment not to abandon unfinished projects. We will continue to retool facilities, strengthen emergency and disease surveillance systems, and ensure that health infrastructure is properly aligned with staffing, equipment, and financing. In the 2026 Budget Statement and Economic Policy, provision has been made to commence regional hospitals in Oti, Savannah, and the Western North Regions. This will expand access to quality care. Aligned with the Reset Agenda, we are making strategic investments in local pharmaceutical and vaccine production. The Government has allocated GHC50 million in seed funding to the National Vaccine Institute. In 2025, a local manufacturer secured market authorisation to produce snake venom antiserum right here in Ghana.

We are also finalising steps to implement an advanced market commitment to prioritise locally manufactured vaccines and pharmaceuticals in public procurement. Production of the tetanus diphtheria vaccine is expected to commence this year through a partnership with an Indonesian pharmaceutical firm. Disease control remains our priority in our country's immunisation financing. We will strengthen immunisation financing. In 2025, the vaccine budget for children and pregnant women was increased by 46 per cent, exceeding the GHC171 million. This enabled Ghana to fully and promptly finance all its vaccines and reduce the risk of preventable outbreaks. In 2025, we will also introduce the

Human Papillomavirus (HPV) vaccine to protect young women and girls against cervical cancer.

Mr Speaker, Ghana's Human Immunodeficiency Virus (HIV) prevalence rate is estimated at 1.6 per cent. As I speak with you, there are about 350,000 of our countrymen and women living with HIV and Acquired Immunodeficiency Syndrome (AIDS). Although prevalence is low, some population segments and regions have significantly higher incidence than the national average. The Ghana AIDS Commission has been tasked with ensuring the availability of testing and antiretrovirals. This year, Government will fully roll out a Free Primary Health Care Programme, removing all cost barriers at the primary level where it is most needed, while strengthening prevention, screening, and health promotion, especially for non-communicable diseases.

The Ghana Medical Trust Fund will be scaled up, and access to advanced cardiac care, including cardiac catheterisation services at Tamale, Korle-Bu and Komfo Anokye Hospital, will be expanded to reduce overseas referrals and position Ghana as a centre for specialised care in the sub-region, in line with our medical tourism objectives.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Health is expected to issue guidelines to eliminate the unacceptable "no-bed" syndrome—*[Hear! Hear!]*—. Patients facing medical emergencies must be received and given help, if even under makeshift conditions.

11:57 a.m.

You do not need to have a comfortable bed to save a patient. No patient must be turned away from any health facility they report to.

Mr Speaker, in the meantime, government will expand capacity by implementing the Ridge Hospital Phase II project to increase the number of beds at the Greater Accra Regional Hospital. We will also continue and complete the Police Hospital project and also continue and complete the La General Hospital. In the Ashanti region, we will complete the Sewua Regional Hospital, we will complete the Afari Military Hospital and we will complete the Komfo Anokye Teaching Hospital Maternity and Children's Block. We remain on course to build a stronger, more resilient and more self-reliant health system for all Ghanaians.

Mr Speaker, roads are a very important sector. We inherited a burden of significant financial obligations and structural pressures in the road sector that had accumulated over the years. As of December 2024, outstanding payments on road projects financed through the Consolidated Fund stood at GH¢21 billion. These were certified works executed by contractors across the country for which payment had not been made. In addition, indebtedness to contractors that was lodged with the Ghana Road Fund Secretariat and awaiting payment amounted to GH¢5.43 billion. This figure excludes accruing interest charges, which continue to compound the financial exposure of the State.

Mr Speaker, beyond these arrears, we also inherited contractual commitments, that is, signed contracts totalling more than GH¢104 billion. These commitments represent signed contracts for road projects at various stages of execution, many of them without corresponding secured funding to guarantee timely completion. By the end of 2025, the Ministry of Finance and Ministry of Roads and Highways had cleared arrears amounting to almost GH¢10 billion owed to road contractors, and we are steadily continuing to reduce the road sector debts.

Mr Speaker, the famous Big Push Infrastructure Programme is my vision for a national infrastructure drive to restore critical national infrastructure. Naturally, the bulk of the money is dedicated to the road sector. We want to open economic corridors, create jobs and reduce the cost of doing business. As I speak to you, work has started on 50 major road projects that cover a distance of 1,144 kilometres. The total estimated cost of these projects is GH¢50 billion. Meanwhile, Government is also completing 23 projects that were awarded by the previous administration but were not paid for. These projects amount to another 573 kilometres and are estimated to cost GH¢15 billion. So, if you add that to the 1,500, it means about 2,000 kilometres of roads are currently undergoing rehabilitation as I speak.

This is the biggest major investment in our road sector in the history of Ghana. Across all 16 regions, 73 projects are advancing with significant visible

progress expected by the end of the year. Some of these include Tapa–Mabang–Goaso Road, the Kumasi Bypass Road, Suame Interchange and Local Roads, Sunyani Outer Ring Road, Sampa-Jinijini Road, Techiman-Nkonsia-Wenchi Road, Dualisation of Winneba-Cape Coast Road, Kwahu-Tafo-Adawso Road, Dodowa-Afienya-Dawhenya Road, Gbintiri-Nakpanduri Road, Tamale Outer Ring Road, Wenchi-Sawla Road, Sawla-Wa Road, Bole-Chache Road and Bole Town Roads, Navrongo-Tumu Road, Tumu-Han-Lawra Road, Atimkoku-Ho Road, Ho-Denu Road, Dualisation of Accra-Aflao Road Phase I, Dualisation of Cape Coast-Takoradi Road, Dadieso-Akontombra Road, to name just a few. Other feeder roads are Akosombo-Gyakiti-Kudikope, Yeniam Junction-Sedorm, Apeguso-Mpakadan, Todome-Toh-Kpalime-Dzemeni roads.

Indeed, there are others too numerous to mention. And as I said at the launch of the Big Push Programme, the whole of Ghana is going to become a construction site. Ghanaians can already testify that serious roadworks are underway across the country.

Mr Speaker, the Accra-Kumasi Expressway will be a 198.7 kilometre six-lane high-speed motorway. This expressway is designed to connect Ghana's two largest cities, Accra and Kumasi, and to reduce the travelling time between Accra and Kumasi to approximately two and a half hours. This new alignment will have eight interchanges and will be Ghana's first true expressway. Government has established the Accra-Kumasi Expressway

Limited, which is a subsidiary of the Ghana Infrastructure Investment Fund, as the concessionaire that will be mandated to design, to finance, construct, operate and maintain the expressway, with the Ministry of Roads and Highways as the contracting authority. The project delivery is structured as a long-term concession of up to 50 years. Mr Speaker, this expressway will be Ghana's first purpose-built expressway with limited access points, so goats and sheep cannot cross at any point. It is designed for higher speed limits and modern safety infrastructure to reduce travel time and improve road safety. Preparatory activities including feasibility studies, the detailed designs and cost assessments are currently underway. This major road construction work aims to improve mobility, safety and trade while connecting communities to markets and essential services.

Mr Speaker, we aim to complete all unfinished segments of the Eastern Corridor Road by the end of 2027. We will continue and complete the 27.7km Accra-Tema Motorway and Extension Projects. And this includes reconstructing the Accra-Tema Motorway into a four-lane expressway with three-lane service routes in both directions and interchanges at Ashaiman. Where you have the Ashaiman under-bridge will now be an interchange. There will be another interchange at Community 18 and Teshie Link. It also involves remodelling the Tetteh-Quarshie Interchange. Construction works are ongoing and progress is at 32 per cent. Other important projects

include the Kumasi Inner Ring Road, the Volivo Bridge over the Southern Volta River, the Dambai Bridge over the River Oti and the Adawso Bridge over the River Afram at Ekye-Amanfrom.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Roads and Highways has received Cabinet approval to reintroduce road tolls on our roads and our bridges. This time using advanced technology to improve efficiency, transparency and avoid leakages in revenue generation. Preparatory work is underway to ensure the reintroduction of tolling operations this year. There is no doubt that an effective and efficient transport system is integral to any economic development plan.

12:07 p.m.

So, to improve public transport services in the country, the Government is supporting Intercity STC Coaches Limited, Metro Mass Transit Limited and the private road transport operators to renew their fleets. Currently, a total of 300 buses have been procured to improve road transport. The initial batch of 100 buses is scheduled to arrive in the country by the end of the first quarter of this year.

Mr Speaker, in fulfilment of my pledge to re-establish a national airline, a 10-member task force established to oversee this initiative has submitted a business model and operational framework to guide the selection of a strategic partner for the new national airline. This new national airline will take off soon, *Insha Allah*.

Mr Speaker, passenger traffic handled by the Ghana Airports Company increased to 3.625 million passengers in 2025. This was an increase from 3.4 million in 2024. In response to the rising passenger traffic and congestion at the Accra International Airport's new Terminal 3, we are remodelling Terminal 2 into a dual-purpose facility to serve both domestic and international flights. So, when the remodelling of Terminal 2 is finished, all domestic flights and some international flights will be moved to Terminal 2 to ease congestion at Terminal 3. This will improve operational efficiency and enhance the overall passenger experience.

Mr Speaker, Accra's Terminal 3 remains among the best in Africa. A new concourse will link Terminal 2 and Terminal 3 so that passengers arriving in Terminal 2 and having to move to Terminal 3 would not have to come out and walk. They will go through the concourse. Mr Speaker, Terminal 3 will be supported by a new seven-storey car park. It will also have an airport hotel and retail amenities to service its passengers.

Mr Speaker, runway expansion and overlay are currently being undertaken to strengthen the Accra International Airport's runway. We will also begin work on new regional airports in Sunyani, Bolgatanga and Wa. In Sunyani, the current location of the airport is not appropriate to extend the runway, so we have to move and build a new airport at a different location. For Bolgatanga, the site has been acquired, and work will commence. We also have to move the Wa airport because it almost

intersects the road, and the airport slopes upward, making it inappropriate for air travel.

Mr Speaker, we are also reverting the international airport in Accra to its original name, the Accra International Airport. *[Hear! Hear!]* Even though the National Liberation Council (NLC) Decree 129 was passed, no effort was made to effect the clause in the decree that said that the airport should be renamed after Kotoka. So, in all international records of the International Civil Aviation Organisation (ICAO) and the International Air Transport Association (IATA), the airport in Accra, the international airport, remains named "Accra International Airport". *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, we are working to fully operationalise the Tema-Mpakadan Rail Line to maximise passenger and freight traffic between Tema and the North using the Volta Lake Waterway. The Western and Eastern Railway Lines will continue to be modernised in partnership with the private sector. These projects are aimed at supporting the efficient transport of container and bulk cargo to and from our ports, as well as facilitating the efficient haulage of minerals from Mines in Nsuta, Awaso and Nyinahin to the Takoradi ports, while also providing passenger transport along the respective rail corridors.

Mr Speaker, as part of the 24-Hour Economy initiative, a new 24-hour operation has started at Tema Ports, allowing access to port services around the clock. This development enables

importers to clear their goods at any time, significantly easing congestion at the terminals like the Transit terminals, the Reefer terminal, and the Golden Jubilee Terminal. The initiative brings together customs, banking, and other relevant agencies to enhance efficiency, lower transaction costs, and boost Ghana's competitiveness as a major trade hub. The Cabinet has reviewed the designs and feasibility study for the Keta Port and directed the Ghana Ports and Harbours Authority (GPHA) to present an action plan and a roadmap for the realisation of the project at the earliest possible time.

Mr Speaker, the Driver and Vehicle Licensing Authority (DVLA), as part of its expansion efforts, has established a new operational office at the Adenta Bus Terminal in Accra. If you need any service from DVLA at night, go to Adenta. There is an office open day and night. This modern facility operates around the clock, providing continuous service to improve accessibility and convenience for our motorists in Adentan Municipality and the general Accra area.

Mr Speaker, communication is important, and under the Rural Telephony and Digital Inclusion Project, implemented through the Ghana Investment Fund for Electronic Communications (GIFEC), we extend voice and data connectivity to unserved and underserved communities. We have targeted the construction of 2,016 cell sites all over underserved and unserved communities. 1,561 of the 2,016 cell sites have been constructed, and 1,144

have been activated. Work is ongoing to activate the remaining 417 sites. Preparations are also well underway to commence construction of the remaining 455 sites.

Mr Speaker, under the School Connectivity Initiative, over 62,000 digital resources have been uploaded to the Ghana Knowledge and Skills Bank, enabling seamless access across multiple devices, from PCs to laptops to tablets and smartphones, for more than 600,000 users, including teachers, students, and researchers. Mr Speaker, as part of the Government's research agenda to ensure Ghanaian youth acquire essential digital skills for the modern global economy, I launched the One Million Coders Programme in March 2025. This initiative aimed to train one million Ghanaians in key digital areas, including data analytics, data protection, cybersecurity, the metaverse, and artificial intelligence, over four years.

Phase one of the programme, that is, the pilot phase, saw hundreds of trainees complete their training programmes in person across four training centres established in Accra, Kumasi, Sunyani, and Bolgatanga. Phase two, which will include virtual sessions, is set to commence this year. With expanded training centres and an increased number of beneficiaries, we project that 400,000 young Ghanaians will be trained this year, and this will build up to the numbers approaching one million.

Mr Speaker, the fight against corruption has remained a defining priority of my government and represents

a central pillar of our commitment to good governance and accountability and the prudent management of public resources. We have made progress through strengthened collaboration among law enforcement agencies, financial intelligence institutions, and prosecutors. These efforts have led to the initiation of criminal proceedings and asset forfeiture proceedings against some individuals and entities implicated in financial crimes against the state. But yes, I agree with the sentiments of Ghanaians that we must press harder on this accelerator.

As of December 2025, the Economic and Organised Crime Office (EOCO) has recovered more than GH¢600 million. The Office has investigated 462 cases, with 15 currently under prosecution. It has dismantled transnational carjacking syndicates and has recovered 29 luxury vehicles that were stolen.

12:17 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Government remains resolute that corruption will not be tolerated, regardless of status or political affiliation. The Attorney General's Office will continue to use both criminal prosecution and non-conviction-based asset recovery mechanisms to ensure that stolen public resources are returned for national development.

Mr Speaker, I understand that a large majority of Ghanaians are impatient to see those who abuse their public trust in office held to account. There were periods when, under military regimes

and unconstitutional governments, extrajudicial means could be used to exact retribution against persons perceived as corrupt or who had abused the mandate given to them by the people. This may have appeared as swift justice, but many regrettable excesses were recorded.

In 1992, we overwhelmingly adopted the 1992 Constitution to accept governance by the rule of law. On 7th January, when I swore the Oath of Office before the people of Ghana, I swore to uphold the 1992 Constitution. I may be as impatient as everyone else to see justice done, but painstaking investigations must be conducted, dockets must be prepared, charges must be filed, and the accused must have their day in court, including appealing even on the smallest point of law to higher courts. This process is necessary to protect us all against abuse or ill-treatment of citizens and to ensure that only those guilty of offences against the State are punished. As President Mills of blessed memory said, and I quote, "The wheels of justice grind slowly, but they grind exceedingly fine."

Mr Speaker, let me reassert my determination to uphold the accountability of public office holders to the people of Ghana. We have laid the Public Officers Code of Conduct Bill before Parliament. This Bill codifies the conduct of public officers and makes breaches thereof punishable. I wish at this juncture to thank His Lordship, the Chief Justice, for establishing additional specialised high courts to address breaches identified in the Auditor General's report.

Mr Speaker, the Constitution review process was conducted in a transparent and consultative, and participatory manner, drawing on input from constitutional experts, civil society organisations, traditional authorities, religious leaders, political parties, and the general public. The Review Committee has submitted its comprehensive report containing detailed proposals to amend the Constitution to address identified weaknesses and make it more welfare enhancing.

Mr Speaker, the Office of the Attorney General and Ministry of Justice is working closely with relevant stakeholders to translate the recommendations into implementable legal and constitutional proposals, which will be presented to this august House in accordance with constitutional procedures.

Mr Speaker, illegal mining continues to pose a grave threat to our environment, water bodies, public health, and national security. Prosecution of persons engaged in illegal mining has been intensified, with a renewed focus on dismantling organised criminal networks behind *galamsey* operations, rather than targeting only the “little fish”, low-level offenders. In all these *galamsey* operations, there are big fish who never get caught. In total, over 114 case dockets involving hundreds of accused persons are pending in various courts across the country, particularly in towns and villages that are prone to illegal mining. Specialised prosecutorial teams have been deployed to fast-track illegal mining cases, ensure the effective presentation of evidence, and pursue the

confiscation and forfeiture of equipment and proceeds used in or derived from illegal mining.

Mr Speaker, when it comes to gender and social protection, my Government will continue to ensure gender equality and equity, promote the welfare and protection of children’s rights, and empower the vulnerable, the aged, and persons with disabilities for sustainable national development. Work is well advanced on the Women’s Development Bank, for which a total of GH401 million have been allocated in the 2026 Budget. The coming months will see a full rollout of this monumental policy to empower Ghanaian women and women-owned businesses economically and financially.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Gender, Children and Social Protection has successfully honoured all legacy leap payment cycles for 2025 and before, reaching 1.5 million people. It has also ensured the full implementation of the Ghana School Feeding Programme in over 12,000 public schools across all 261 districts of this country.

Mr Speaker, the number of beneficiary pupils under the School Feeding Programme has increased from 3,801,491 for the 2023/2024 academic year to 4,231,059 for the 2024/2025 academic year. This programme is providing gainful employment to 34,000 caretakers and cooks nationwide.

Mr Speaker, in the security sector, Ghana faces evolving security threats. Our troops, services, and agencies have, however, remained firmly committed to

strengthening national peace and security, which underpin our democracy, development, and social cohesion. This commitment encompasses internal security operations, international peace support missions, strategic investment in restructuring and retooling, improvement in troops' welfare, recruitment, and capacity development.

Mr Speaker, two recent incidents are evidence of the increasing dangers we face as a nation. The killing of eight of our compatriots who had gone to a neighbouring country to purchase tomatoes, and just yesterday, an attack on Ghanaian fishermen in our waters by pirates reinforced the need for us to retool and adequately equip our security services.

Mr Speaker, I wish to commend the Ghana Armed Forces for conducting a successful medical evacuation of our injured compatriots from Burkina Faso. I also commend the Ghana Navy and the Ghana Air Force, the National Security Council Secretariat, the Chief of Staff's Operations Team, the Member of Parliament for Awutu Senya, the Chief Fisherman, and the people of Senya Beraku for the combined effort that successfully rescued all the stranded 71 fishermen who had been attacked by pirates. I have asked the National Security Coordinator to assist the affected fishermen and replace the stolen outboard motors and fishing gear.

Mr Speaker, the Armed Forces continue to play a key role in containing illegal small-scale mining through the

deployment of river guards and support for the National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat, and assistance to special courts for swift prosecution of offenders. During the year, the Ghana Armed Forces had 2,119 troops with requisite equipment deployed in various peacekeeping missions, reinforcing Ghana's reputation as a dependable and professional contributor to international peacekeeping operations. While Ghana continues to maintain an enviable reputation in international peacekeeping, we must note that many of these peacekeeping theatres where we have operated are winding down due to reduced budgets for United Nations (UN) peace support operations. So, as our troops return home, we must create opportunities for them to train, to remain active, and stay engaged.

Mr Speaker, beyond peacekeeping operations, Ghana continues to demonstrate its strong commitment to international solidarity, humanitarian assistance, and South-South cooperation. In December, 2025, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, in conjunction with the Ministry of Defence, deployed 54 personnel from our 14th Engineers Brigade to Jamaica to support that country with national reconstruction efforts following the devastation that was caused by Hurricane Melissa, which claimed over 40 lives. In recognition of the scale of the recovery efforts and the good work our soldiers were doing in reconstructing the houses in Jamaica, Government approved a request from the government of Jamaica asking us to extend the mandates of our soldiers there for another 90 days, which we approved.

Mr Speaker, to further improve operational readiness, the Government will continue to invest in vital defence infrastructure and retooling.

12:27 p.m.

The construction of a Forward Operating Base at Ezinlibo, situated along the Western Maritime Corridor, is ongoing. This facility aims to boost maritime surveillance and better protect offshore oil and gas installations. The Northern Border Security Project, initiated to counter terrorism and transnational crime, is advancing decisively. This project constitutes the first line of defence against any infiltration and extremist threats coming from the Sahel, and would significantly strengthen the surveillance of our northern border. Plans are well advanced to establish two new military barracks in Ajumako in the Central Region, and in Dambai in the Oti Region, to address emerging security concerns and strengthen the presence of the State in these areas.

To further support retooling efforts, agreements have been signed to procure and deliver four brand new Eurocopter helicopters and one jet for the Ghana Air Force, aimed at replacing the ageing fleet and modernising our air capabilities. The Ghana Armed Forces is carrying out a thorough overhaul of previously grounded aircraft, which involves replacing essential components and bringing them back into service. This aims to quickly restore their operational readiness and maximise our fleet availability.

Mr Speaker, I am pleased to announce that I have further commissioned 50 new vehicles for the Ghana Armed Forces to enhance mobility and boost troop morale. It forms part of a broader programme to retool the military and improve logistics across the services. Plans are underway to acquire two brand new offshore patrol vessels, armoured personnel carriers, protective gear, ammunition, vehicles, and strategic drones, and advanced communication systems to enhance the operational capability of the Army, Navy, and Air Force.

We will also continue to prioritise human capital development within the Armed Forces. A progressive recruitment drive to increase the strength of the Ghana Armed Forces by 12,000 personnel over four years to support expansion and operational demands is ongoing. In line with the Government's Reset Agenda, the recruitment process has been decentralised to regional capitals with selected recruits reporting directly from their regions to training schools, marking a significant shift from the previous Accra-centred system.

Mr Speaker, on a very solemn note, I wish to express my condolences to the families of six of our young daughters who died during the stampede at the El-Wak Stadium. May their memory be blessed and may they rest in perfect peace.

Mr Speaker, following the revised gratuity regime that was introduced in 2020 under the stewardship of Hon Dominic Nitiwul, extending service by

five years under Constitutional Instrument 129, arrears have accumulated. Mr Nitiwul is my Friend, do not worry. *[Laughter]* —because no budgetary provision was made over the four years that followed.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin, when we all leave politics, Mr Nitiwul and I will be going to the same place in the north. You will go to Winneba. *[Laughter]* Do not worry, we are Brothers.

Mr Speaker, this has resulted in over GH¢1 billion owed to approximately 3,000 personnel across all the different ranks. As part of our commitment to fairness and the resolution of long-standing legacy issues, the Government will soon commence payments of gratuity arrears under C.I. 129. Hon Nitiwul, we are solving the problem, so you will not worry about it again. *[Laughter]*

Mr Speaker, following engagements that were initiated by the current Military High Command with the Ministry of Finance and the Ministry of Defence, a structured implementation plan has been agreed upon. This will bring closure to the issue that has been outstanding since 2020, and it will ensure that affected personnel receive their rightful entitlements.

Mr Speaker, the Ghana Police Service has also received 40 armoured vehicles and 100 pickup trucks to enhance their operations. Other security agencies such as the Ghana Fire Service, Ghana Prisons Service, Ghana Immigration Service, Bureau of National

Investigations, and Narcotics Control Commission will also be retooled to enhance their efficiency.

Mr Speaker, let me take this moment to commend the Inspector-General of Police (IGP) and his men for the recent major successes they are chalking and bringing dangerous criminals to justice. The trust of the Ghanaian people in their police service is rising again, and I urge them to keep up the standard.

Mr Speaker, Ghana's foreign policy remains a central instrument for advancing our national development for safeguarding our sovereignty and projecting our values on the global stage. At a time when the global environment is characterised by profound geopolitical shifts, economic uncertainty, climate-related challenges, and security concerns within our sub-region, Government has taken deliberate steps to ensure that Ghana's engagement with the world is purposeful, strategic, and responsive to the needs of our people. In this regard, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs has stepped up efforts to align Ghana's external relations with our domestic development priorities.

Mr Speaker, in West Africa, Ghana continues to pursue a policy of good neighbourliness, solidarity, and constructive cooperation with all countries in the sub-region. We remain firmly committed to the vision of a peaceful, stable, prosperous, and integrated West Africa, grounded in mutual respect, dialogue, and collective responsibility. We must sustain engagement and deepen relations with

our sister *Alliance des États du Sahel* (AES) member states, particularly following their withdrawal from the Economic Community of West African States (ECOWAS). Ghana believes that continued dialogue and cooperation are indispensable to regional stability, and that disengagement only deepens our collective vulnerabilities.

At the continental level, Ghana continues to play an active, principled, and forward-looking role in advancing the African Union's (AU) strategic priorities. Today, Ghana currently holds the following prestigious positions. We are AU champions on reparations. We are AU champions for African financial institutions, and Ghana is also the AU champion for gender equality and women's empowerment. *[Hear! Hear!]*

Mr Speaker, I am humbled by my election as the first Vice Chairperson of the African Union at the 39th Ordinary Session of the AU Assemblies of Heads of State and Government held recently in Addis Ababa, Ethiopia. Mr Speaker, it is also gratifying to note that my colleague leaders in West Africa have declared me, John Dramani Mahama, President of the Republic of Ghana and Commander-in-Chief of the Ghana Armed Forces, they have declared me unopposed by the grace of God, the sole candidate for the position of Chairperson of the African Union when the rotating chairmanship returns to West Africa in 2027. *[Hear! Hear!]*

[Members of the Majority Side chanted]

Mr Speaker, during the 80th Session of the United Nations General Assembly, I raised Ghana's voice to call for a comprehensive reset of the United Nations to better reflect the current realities and particularly the role of Africa in global governance and fairness in international financial systems. In line with our multilateral commitments, Ghana announced plans to table a United Nations Resolution that recognises the Transatlantic Slave Trade as the gravest crime against humanity. I am promoting an agenda of acknowledgement, reparative justice and cultural restitution. Mr Speaker, I will formally present this Resolution which has been endorsed and adopted by the African Union unanimously to the UN in March of this year for consideration by the UN General Assembly.

Mr Speaker, passports have never been easier to acquire than under this regime.

12:37 p.m.

Mr Speaker, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs has established seven new passport application centres in Upper East, Oti, Ahafo, Bono East, North East, my own Region Savannah and the Western North Region. Mr Speaker, with this expansion, all 16 regional capitals now host passport application centres, marking a major milestone in the decentralisation of passport services.

Mr Speaker, to address systemic delays, the Ministry implemented a 24-hour passport production operation at the head office. This enabled the clearance

of an inherited backlog of over 40,000 passport applications. As a result of these reforms, Ghana's passport administration now operates with zero backlog, guaranteeing passport delivery within 15 working days. If you would like to try it, apply for a new passport. Within 15 days, you will receive your passport.

Mr Speaker, to facilitate travel, boost tourism and ease business mobility, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs implemented a five-day visa processing service across all Ghana's Missions abroad. What this means is that anyone who applies for a visa will get the visa within five days.

Concurrently, significant progress has been made in the design and procurement phase of a national e-visa platform with a targeted rollout plan for 2026. This means if you apply for a visa online, the visa is approved online. One does not need to go to the Ghana Embassy to apply.

Ghana has also secured new visa waiver agreements with 11 countries to facilitate people-to-people exchange. It means for those 11 countries, Ghanaians do not need passports to go there. One just jumps on the plane and appear there and they will allow one in.

Mr Speaker, to highlight Ghana's ongoing commitments to international solidarity, we made humanitarian donations to Jamaica, Cuba, Sudan and Palestine to support disaster relief and conflict-related crises. These donations amounted to millions of cedis and included food, medicine, clothing, cocoa products, blankets, mattresses and

plastic buckets. Mr Speaker, I am also pleased to report that remittances from our relatives abroad, the Ghanaian diaspora, reached a historic high of US\$7.8 billion in 2025.

Mr Speaker, this is the largest annual inflow ever recorded in Ghana's history. This reflects not only confidence in the Ghanaian economy, but the enduring patriotism of our citizens living and working abroad. These remittances they bring back home, support households, they finance education, they build homes, they provide seed money for businesses and best of all, they stabilise our foreign exchange position.

In many respects, our diaspora has become one of the country's most reliable development partners. Without contracts, conditionalities or fanfare, they are easily one of our most reliable development partners. We must intentionally ensure that citizenship, rather than place of residence, determines one's right to serve the Ghanaian Republic.

Ghanaians worldwide who pledge allegiance to this country of theirs and make substantial contributions to its development should not be barred from active participation in public affairs, including the opportunity to hold public office, provided there are appropriate measures to ensure loyalty and accountability. Mr Speaker, I am personally in support of the bipartisan Bill currently before this House, seeking to address this matter. And it is my hope that it will be passed expeditiously so that our compatriots abroad can participate in our public affairs.

Mr Speaker, youth development and empowerment are at the core of everything we are trying to achieve. We are implementing many policies to develop our youth capacity and to create as many jobs as possible to address the major unemployment problem. All our youth activities and job creation programmes are ongoing.

In 2025, 10,887 young people were trained in entrepreneurship programmes and job creation under the *Adwumawura* Programme. In 2026, an additional 10,000 young people received similar support under the Programme. The National Apprenticeship Programme onboarded 14,000 young apprentices during the piloting phase and they have started receiving their start-up kits after passing out successfully.

Training is ongoing across the regions and when completed, the trainees will be certified by the Commission for TVET to facilitate their access to employment. Mr Speaker, this year, the target for the National Apprenticeship Programme has been increased from 10,000 to 100,000 young people, offering many more young people the opportunity to acquire the skills needed for sustainable employment. And as I said, when they pass out, they are given a certificate by TVET to show that they have passed out and have the skill in whatever they learned.

In 2025, 86,000 young people were engaged through the Youth Employment Agency's various employment modules. This year, I have directed the Ministry of Youth Development and Empowerment

to, as a matter of urgency, review all the youth employment modules under the Youth Employment Agency (YEA) to reduce duplication and ensure value for money. This is important so that we can channel the resources to the advantage of the teeming youth who are waiting for opportunity.

Mr Speaker, the National Service Authority has signed a Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) with the Ministry of Defence to commence military training for 10,000 National Service Personnel in the 2025/2026 service year. So, our National Service Personnel will receive call-ups to reports at various military centres for training.

This was a programme initiated by our late Minister for Defence of Blessed Memory, Dr Edward Omane Boamah, who was desirous of seeing it to full execution. I therefore charge the National Service Authority and the Ghana Armed Forces to bring life into the exercise for the benefit of the personnel and the training of our young people.

Mr Speaker, my Government has launched a wide range of initiatives aimed at transforming Ghana's trade and agribusiness and industrial sectors to boost our competitiveness in export markets, encourage value addition and generate employment for Ghana's large youth population. My recent visits with the hardworking Minister for Trade, Agribusiness and Industry to inaugurate new factories and initiate expansion works on factories has convinced me that Ghana is on the right track for industrial transformation.

The Ministry has begun implementing policies in the areas of textile and garment manufacturing, pharmaceuticals and vaccine manufacturing, automotive and components manufacturing and contract farming and agro-processing. As a first step, we are collaborating with the private sector to establish three new garment factories in the Eastern Region, Central Region and the Bono East Region. This will create an estimated 27,000 jobs.

This Government will fulfil its commitment to revive key state-owned enterprises. The Ministry is in the process of sourcing strategic investors to operationalise the Volta Star Textiles Factory, the Komenda Sugar Factory, the Pwalugu Tomato Factory, the Zuarungu Meat Factory and the Akosombo Textiles Limited.

Ghana's non-traditional exports recorded a 27.04 per cent growth in 2025, with total earnings of US\$4.87 billion, up from US\$3.83 billion in 2024. This reflects a very early impact of the Accelerated Exports Development Programme, launched only last year and demonstrates the continued resilience and expanding contribution of the non-traditional export sector to Ghana's export economy.

Mr Speaker, the mining sub-sector remains a cornerstone of Ghana's economic development, making substantial contributions to employment creation, export earnings and government revenue. According to the Ghana Statistics Service, the mining and quarrying sub-sector accounted for 17.4

per cent of the overall 33.8 per cent of industry share of GDP in 2025. It emerged as a leading contributor within the industrial sector. The sector generated export earnings of approximately US\$15.25 billion, accounting for 65.37 per cent of Ghana's total export receipts, out of a total of US\$23.3 billion.

Mr Speaker, the abolition of value-added tax on mineral exploration activities is expected to significantly reduce upfront costs for investors, improve projects, economics and stimulate increased greenfield and brownfield explorations across the country.

12:47 p.m.

The fight against *galamsey* remains complex and demands a multidimensional response that integrates strong enforcement, the application of technology, sound regulation and active community participation. The Ministry of Lands and Natural Resources, in collaboration with the Ministry of Transport, the Ghana Revenue Authority (GRA), and the Ministry of Finance, has registered 1,808 pieces of earth-moving equipment at the Port, of which 1,033 have been fitted with trackers and are being tracked.

The protection of our water bodies and forest reserves is ongoing with the deployment of 1,634 Blue Water Guards across Western, Western North, Savannah, Upper West, Bono, Eastern, Ashanti, Central, Volta and Northern Regions. This nationwide deployment aims to strengthen surveillance, improve

rapid response, and enhance on-the-ground enforcement against illegal mining activities that threaten critical water bodies, forest ecosystems and livelihoods. Mr Speaker, the National Anti-Illegal Mining Operations Secretariat (NAIMOS) will maintain regular coordinated operations across all 21 identified hotspots to prevent re-entry of illegal miners into these reserves. While temporary deployments yielded positive results, they proved insufficient for sustained enforcement.

Mr Speaker, in the Works, Housing, and Water Resources subsector, these are vital pillars of Ghana's national development, shaping sustainable livelihoods through reliable water supply and affordable housing that enhance citizens' well-being. Sea defence works are ongoing. We have successfully completed works at Komenda, Ningo Prampram, and Elmina. Together, these three projects have protected approximately 15 km of our coastline and safeguarded lives, livelihoods and property.

In March 2025, I visited Salakope, Agavedzi, and Amutinu in the Ketu South Municipality, where tidal waves had displaced thousands of residents. We made a firm commitment to address the devastation. Mr Speaker, true to that promise, the contractor for Phase II of the Blekusu Coastal Protection Works was awarded the contract and in August last year, I officially inaugurated the project. I am pleased to inform this House that the project is currently 25 per cent complete and calm has already been restored along the coastline.

Notwithstanding these actions, flooding remains a major infrastructural challenge in the country and a top priority for this Government. A taskforce on flooding is in place and coordinating the national mitigation efforts against flooding.

Ghana continues to grapple with housing deficits, currently estimated at over 1.8 million units. Some significant strides have been made in the housing sector. In line with Government's earlier commitments to complete all ongoing housing initiatives, we have successfully concluded the joint venture arrangement which we inherited for the completion of the Saglemi Housing Project.

The Attorney-General and Minister for Justice is reviewing all related documentation to finalise and commence the project. When these projects are finished, it will increase the number of housing stocks available. The Tema Development Corporation (TDC) in Ghana is also steadily advancing work on 800 housing units under its Kpone Affordable Housing Project at Tema Community 26.

To position TDC Ghana as a key player in Ghana's housing industry, I performed an inauguration ceremony last year for what they call the Oxygen City Housing Project in Ho of all places. That project seeks to address Ghana's housing deficit by developing 1,000 affordable housing units. We have also continued with our resettlement housing efforts for the victims of the Akosombo Dam spillage, with 251 of the planned 1,010 housing units in critical housing zones

already under construction. Collectively, these initiatives demonstrate Government's continued resolve to expand access to affordable housing, strengthen urban planning, and provide relief to affected communities.

Mr Speaker, renewable water resources are estimated at about 54 billion cubic metres, with over 70 per cent derived from the Volta River, which is shared among six riparian nations. We are implementing key interventions to expand and improve water services nationwide. The following urban water supply projects are at various stages of completion: The Keta Water Works, the Wenchi Water Supply Project and the Sekondi-Takoradi Water Supply Project.

I am happy to announce that Anyako has good and clean drinking water today and the Community Water and Sanitation Agency (CWSA) will inaugurate the project next week. It will also serve the island community of Seva.

We will begin preparatory work on the Damongo and Sunyani Water Supply Expansion Projects and seek to finalise all financing arrangements for other water supply projects in Tamale, Yendi, Techiman and Tarkwa. Mr Speaker, the Danish Government has allocated grant support to improve water supply services in low-income and high-density areas in Wa and Bolgatanga, aiming to address water challenges and provide relief to vulnerable populations. Mr Speaker, the following rural water supply projects are ongoing: Asankragwa, Sefwi Wiawso, Duadaso, Kweiman Danfa, Goaso, Juaben, Aveyime, and Adum Bansa.

To strictly follow the Resetting Agenda and secure sufficient funding, the Ministry of Finance has allocated GHC6.3 billion to the District Assemblies Common Fund (DACF). This amount covers four quarters of the 2025 fiscal year and it has been allocated to all 261 Metropolitan, Municipal, and District Assemblies (MMDAs) to execute the activities outlined in the Medium-Term Development Plans and Annual Action Plans (AAPs). Mr Speaker, out of the amount released, a total of GHC4.3 billion has been disbursed to all MMDAs. The fourth quarter instalment is being processed and will be disbursed soon.

Mr Speaker, all Members of this House will agree with me that the flow of resources to the district assemblies is unprecedented. *[Hear! Hear!]* All your Assemblies are receiving more money than they have ever received in several years. Mr Speaker, in fulfilment of Government's commitment to strengthen local governance and decentralisation, the Ministry has for the first time in the history of local governance, disbursed a total of GHC100 million in monthly allowances to all Assembly Members. *[Hear! Hear!]* Unprecedented! Assembly Members have received their allowances. The Ministry of Local Government, Chieftaincy and Religious Affairs has also finalised designs for the new 24-Hour Economy Modern Markets to be adopted and constructed in all MMDAs. Mr Speaker, procurement processes are far advanced to commence the construction of these markets. And very soon, in all your Districts, Hon Members, you will have a 24-Hour market operational.

Mr Speaker, our Tourism and Creative Arts sector has a lot to offer. Creatives using new media are giving our nation greater prominence than we could have achieved through any first-class traditional media outlet. Our economy will not be built only by traditional sectors, but also by human creativity sectors that will absorb those people who will be displaced from the shop floor by the new Artificial Intelligence (A.I.) technologies that are being rolled out. Ghana has become a favourite tourist destination because of our history, our culture, our arts, our music, our fashion, and our food. The Government has allocated GH¢20 million to the film sector alone. This is going to the film sector to support Kumawood, Ghallywood and all the woods. *[Laughter]* Mr Speaker, another GH¢20 million has been given for the other creative sectors. I believe that this injection of money will bolster our creative sectors.

Mr Speaker, I wish to assure the creative industry and the Ministry of Tourism and Creative Arts that I will be their personal ambassador—*[Hear! Hear!]*—for the promotion of tourism and the creative sector. Mr Speaker, in line with our new national efforts to bring events and conferences to Ghana, we are going to undertake the refurbishment of the Accra International Conference Centre (AICC) to restore it to its iconic past as the country's national and international events and conference venue. Mr Speaker, the original contractors of the Centre, Energoprojekt Ghana Limited, have conducted a structural integrity assessment at the

request of the Office of the Chief of Staff and made recommendations for the facility's renovation and refurbishment.

12:57 p.m.

They will commence this work in the next few weeks.

But, Mr Speaker, the Accra International Conference Centre (AICC) is not enough for a country seeking to develop its creative sector and become West Africa's destination for meetings, conferences, musicals, concerts and entertainment. So, working with the private sector, work will also commence this year on a befitting convention and creative events centre to position Ghana as West Africa's leading hub for meetings, incentives, conferences exhibitions and creative events. Ghana will also begin this year the renovation of the State Banquet Hall, which has been closed for a couple of years.

Mr Speaker, this year we will strengthen Ghana's standing in the major global and continental sporting events. We will make our fifth FIFA World Cup appearance. For us, this is an opportunity to boost national branding and the economy beyond just sports. Supporters and other people who are interested in going to support their team would have to submit a visa request to the Embassy of the United States of America. We are being told that we must ensure that supporters who go return on their visas. It has taken a lot of work to restore Ghana's five-year non-immigrant visas and take us off the ban list. It is my hope

that this event will not send thousands of Ghanaians to America and get us back on the ban list.

Mr Speaker, the Black Queens will compete at the 2026 African Women Cup of Nations, building on their bronze medal finish in Morocco. At the youth level, Ghana will participate in the 2026 Youth Olympic Games in Dakar with a multidisciplinary team aimed at strengthening long-term elite pathways. We will also compete at the Commonwealth Games, 2026, in Glasgow, reinforcing Ghana's presence across the Commonwealth sporting landscape.

Mr Speaker, as a member of the Ghana Journalists Association, I have been deeply concerned about the abuses suffered by journalists at the hands of some of our errant security personnel. I have asked the leadership of the security agencies to take firm action and to reorient their men and women on the need to be accommodating to journalists who are only doing their job of keeping citizens informed. I have also been concerned about the state of our state-owned media, most of which have suffered from historical underfunding and grappling with deteriorating infrastructure and facilities. I recently toured these media houses to learn about their challenges at first hand and we are currently putting together a revitalisation plan to leverage their valuable assets and re-inject life into their operations. The reintroduction of the Media Development Fund is also being reconsidered to support the Ghanaian media.

Mr Speaker, as I conclude, during my recent trip to Zambia, we saw what a united Ghana can achieve on the global stage. A simple mislabelling of our culture could have reduced us to a punchline. Instead, we moved with speed and confidence. We corrected the record. We turned what was supposed to be ridicule into reach. We turned confusion into connection. We taught what could have been a negative social media trend into a handshake of friendship with our Zambian brothers and sisters. [*Hear! Hear!*]

Mr Speaker, for most people, that episode was just a fleeting social media frenzy. Yet it served a greater purpose. It showed a nation that understands its brand, equity. It showed citizens aligned around a common identity. It showed a country that knows who we are and refuses to be defined by others. But let us be honest, unity in moments of cultural pride has proved easier than unity in moments of political disagreement. If we can mobilise that same collective resolve for our development agenda, we will see real progress. And that mobilisation is possible because we are the descendants of a people who united against political subjugation. We resisted economic exploitation and we fought colonial oppression.

Mr Speaker, our pursuit of national development today demands that same unity of purpose. We must reject misrepresentation and distortion that detract from our collective progress. We must guard our development as firmly as we guard our cultural identity. We must act as one people with one purpose.

Mr Speaker, in public life, there is a simple maxim we are all very familiar with and it says that the buck stops with the President. I not only agree with this. Every day I hold office as President, I live by that statement that the buck stops with me. The ultimate responsibility for the direction of this nation rests with the Office that I hold and I will never shirk that duty. But nation building is not merely a question of who provides the strategic direction and who bears the final responsibility. It is a long chain of efforts that carries intent into reality from policy conception to laws enacted, to resources mobilised, to services delivered, to value created on farms, in workshops, in classrooms, in markets and in enterprises across our land. It is here that the strength of a people reveals itself. It is in the countless acts of competence, integrity and industry by citizens of every calling whose work turns national purpose into lived reality. While the buck may stop with me, the work of nation building goes beyond that, through the labour, enterprise and civic spirit of millions of Ghanaians whose daily efforts give policy life.

Mr Speaker, I will continue to carry the weight of final accountability and I ask in equal measure that our citizens bring their full measure of energy, skills and patriotism to the common task of advancing our country. That is how nations are built. That is how economies grow. No policy can substitute for civic duty. No programme can replace the quiet discipline with which millions of Ghanaians sustain their families, serve their communities and carry this republic forward each day.

Mr Speaker, we are sometimes tempted to judge our nation only by our failures and our difficulties. But a country is not defined solely by its difficulties. It is defined by the choices its people make in response to those difficulties. Repeatedly through our history, Ghanaians have chosen steadiness over despair, cooperation over division and purpose over cynicism. That is the deepest strength on which our future rests. We have faced testy moments before and we have overcome them. We have gone through periods of economic strain, transitions that have demanded much from our citizens and our public servants alike.

Mr Speaker, there is an African proverb that says, “however long the night is, the dawn will break.” Mr Speaker, the dawn is breaking for Ghana. [*Hear! Hear!*] The moment we are in requires not only endurance but also action. It reminds us that renewal belongs to those who prepare for the morning while others still speak off and look back at the darkness. For Ghana today, that dawn is not a promise we must recite. It is a reality we must build into our institutions, into our economy and in the ethics of responsibility we pass on to the next generation. So let us live each day mindful that the republic is larger than any one political party, any office, any individual. This Republic belongs equally to the farmer, the trader, the teacher, the nurse, the artisan, the entrepreneur, the parliamentarian, the young citizen and the elderly retired personnel who has carried faith in this nation for decades. Each of these people has a stake in our Nation and each one

has a duty. Each has a claim on the future we are shaping together.

Mr Speaker, nations endure not because they are spared trial but because their people refuse to surrender to trial. Ghana has been tested before. We did not surrender. We will not surrender now. And so, with gratitude for how far we have come and with the resolve for the work ahead, I say, Mr Speaker, the state of our Nation is resilient, the state of our Nation is renewing and our Nation is firmly in the hands of its people. Our Nation is on the brink of take-off and so ladies and gentlemen, passengers, fasten your seatbelts.

I thank you for your attention.
[Hear! Hear!]

1:07 p.m.

[Members of the Majority Side chanted]

[Members of the Minority Side displayed cocoa pods and chanted]

The Speaker: Hon Members—

[The Speaker rises to be heard in silence pursuant to Standing Order 126 (2)]

The Speaker: Hon Members, you know we are in this together, and you understand that, as accomplished parliamentarians, when the Speaker is on his feet to be heard in silence— [Some

Hon Members: Father! o, Father!]
you do not only resume your seats, but you also keep silent. [Hear! Hear!]

Before I convey the gratitude of the House to His Excellency the President for the message, permit me to acknowledge some more senior patriots who are with us here today. We have the leader of the People's National Convention (PNC) in the person of Bernard Anbataayela Mornah. We also have the leader of the All People's Congress (APC), Hassan Abdulai Ayariga. And we have my senior brother, the former flagbearer of the Convention People's Party (CPP), Ivor Kobina Greenstreet, also with us here. Please, you are all warmly welcome.

Hon Members, in accordance with Standing Order 72, rule 4, I convey to His Excellency the President of the Republic of Ghana, the gratitude of the House for the address. Again, in accordance with the practice of this House, a formal communication will be forwarded to His Excellency the President, after the House has thoroughly debated this Message. So, His Excellency will hear from us. I know you already.

Hon Members, by our rules, we are to sit for five hours per sitting, and if it is not up to five hours, the Motion for adjournment must be moved. We have spent a lot of time, but not yet five hours. So, I will call on the Leaders, starting with the Minority Leader. [Hear! Hear!]

Hon Members, in consultation with the Leaders, I am giving each of them five minutes. After that, I will put the Question for adjournment. Yes, Minority Leader.

Minority Leader (Osahen Alexander Kwamena Afenyo-Markin): Mr Speaker, with respect, let me thank you for the opportunity and thank the President for living up to his constitutional obligation.

But, Mr Speaker, what the President failed to tell the people of Ghana is that, after one year in Government, he is still acting on slogans, no action. Electricity tariffs have skyrocketed, and Ghanaians cannot afford electricity. We have thousands of Ghanaian youths who are—Mr Speaker, can they be quiet and listen? Because if they misconduct themselves, we will do the same to their Leader. They should keep quiet.

1:17 p.m.

They cannot take away my time. If they do not keep quiet and listen to me, their Leader cannot speak. If they do not know, I am telling them.

Mr Speaker, thousands of Ghanaian youths were dismissed through a letter by the Chief of Staff; it is part of the State of the Nation Address.

Mr Speaker, as we speak, there is —

[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]—

[Refer to column 5 of the Hansard of 4th March, 2026]

Mr Speaker, on cocoa farmers, they have reduced the producer price, and Hon Eric Opoku cannot be found. They do not care about cocoa farmers, and they are here telling us about inflation, and saying macroeconomics; macroeconomics *na ye be di?*

Mr Speaker, Ghanaians continue to suffer under this *galamsey* hardship, and we expect concrete action to be taken on *galamsey*.

Mr Speaker, to conclude, our elders say, “give credit where credit is due.” Mr President is telling us today that some gains have been made, those gains are through this Gold for Reserves Policy. What they have failed to tell Ghanaians is that the Bawumia whom they attacked is the brainchild of this Gold for Reserves Policy. I would want to urge the Government to give to Bawumia what belongs to Bawumia.

Mr Speaker, we are happy they are showing a picture, trying to embarrass the former Minister for Finance. We have seen it, but let me assure them that soon and very soon

—[Expunged by order of Mr Speaker]—

[Refer to column 5 of the Hansard of 4th March, 2026]

Mr Speaker, I will conclude by saying that this Side of the House is ready today to debate on this Message on the State of the Nation, and by Monday, the true Message on the State of the Nation will be revealed by the

Minority. By Monday, we, the Minority, will present to the people of Ghana the true state of the nation.

Mr Speaker, with that said, let me thank you for the opportunity, and I wish Mr President well. *[Uproar]*

The Speaker: Hon Members, let us now listen to the Majority Leader for five minutes. *[Uproar]*

Majority Leader (Mr Mahama Ayariga): Mr Speaker, on behalf of my Colleagues in this House, we want to thank H. E. President John Dramani Mahama, for his excellent leadership — *[Interruption]*.

The Speaker: Hon Members, please. *[Uproar]*

[Hon Members on the Minority Side sang]

The Speaker: Hon Members, please, we are not at a rally ground. You must know that this House has the power to terminate by law, the Membership of a Member of Parliament—

Hon Members, again, this is just a reminder to all of you.

Majority Leader, you may continue.

Mr Ayariga: We want to thank H. E. President John Dramani Mahama, for his leadership. Ghanaians are very grateful to him.

Mr Speaker, it is obvious that the Ghana the President inherited and the Ghana he speaks of today are like day

and night. The Ghana he inherited was as dark as the dark dresses that they are wearing on the other Side, and the Ghana he speaks of today is clearly as bright as the white dresses that we are wearing on this Side.

Mr Speaker, clearly, everything that the President has said here is true. Hon Afenyo-Markin will attest to that.

1:27 p.m.

He will attest to the fact that the Big Push is pushing through Winneba steadily—*[Hear! Hear!]*—And he is getting premix fuel. Mr Speaker, it seems today is about cocoa prices. I can understand.

Mr Speaker, let me read Reuters. Reuters has confirmed that Ivory Coast will pay cocoa farmers 800 CFA franc to 1,000 CFA franc per kilogramme for the mid-crop starting 1st March. The main crop price was 2,800 CFA franc per kilogramme. When converted to Ghanaian cedis, this is about GH¢980 to GH¢1,225 per 64 kilogramme bag. Mr Speaker, Ivory Coast will pay cocoa farmers 800 CFA to 1,000 CFA franc per kilogramme for the mid-crop starting 1st March. The main crop price was 2,800 CFA per kilogramme. When converted to Ghana series, this is about GH¢980 to GH¢1,225 per 64 kilogramme bag. In Ghana, farmers are paid GH¢2,587 per 64 kilogramme bag, which is more than twice the price in Ivory Coast. *[Hear! Hear!]* This is confirmed this morning by Reuters.

Mr Speaker, I see written on the muffler of my Friends in black that “*NPP yaye mɔbɔ dodo.*”

Mr Speaker, this is the month of Ramadan. Your Excellency, all Muslims in Ghana will pray for Allah's blessings on you for your sterling leadership; leadership that has been recognised by the entire West Africa. That is why they unanimously elected you unopposed to lead in Africa. Ghanaians are proud of you. This Ramadan, many of our people could afford sugar and rice because the prices have come down.

Mr Speaker, let me conclude by seconding the Motion by my Friend the Minority Leader—

The Speaker: Hon Majority Leader, you will now move the Motion for adjournment.

Mr Ayariga: Mr Speaker, I move that this House adjourns until Tuesday in the forenoon. I so move.

Osahen Afenyo-Markin: Mr Speaker, much as we are willing to work, the Majority is unwilling to work. So, Mr Speaker, I will reluctantly second the Motion to grant the pleasure of the Majority Leader who wants to go and rest.

Thank you so much, Mr Speaker.

Question put and Motion agreed to.

ADJOURNMENT

The House was accordingly adjourned at 1:33 p.m. till Tuesday, 3rd March, 2026, at 2:00 p.m.

Editor's Note

This *Official Report* was adopted by the House on 11th March, 2026.